



Mountain Home Maintenance Calendar

A redwood-canyon house runs on a different schedule than a flatland one: fire work in spring, water work in fall, and a short window in between. Stick this on the utility-room wall and work down it.

IF YOU ONLY PROTECT TWO WINDOWS, PROTECT THESE

Spring is when defensible space gets done, while the growth is still green and easy to cut. **September and October** is the big push before the rains, and the stretch where procrastination costs real money. Everything else is upkeep.

JANUARY AND FEBRUARY: STORM SEASON, EYES OPEN

- ☐ After each big storm, walk the property when it is safe. Check that no gutter is overflowing and downspouts move water away from the foundation.
- ☐ Check that the ditches and culverts draining your driveway run clear. A culvert that plugs in January is how driveways disappear.
- ☐ Watch the trees you flagged in the fall. Saturated ground plus wind is when limbs and whole trees come down.
- ☐ If anything falls into power lines, stay away and call 911. For roads, county dispatch is (831) 477-3999.
- ☐ Test smoke and carbon monoxide alarms. Monthly, all year.

MARCH AND APRIL: ASSESS, THEN START THE FIRE WORK

- ☐ Look at the roof from the ground with binoculars: lifted shingles, debris dams, moss holding moisture against the roofing.
- ☐ Check decks, railings, and stairs for winter rot.
- ☐ Note where water pooled or cut channels, and fix the grading or drainage while the memory is fresh.
- ☐ Start defensible space while vegetation is green and soft: ember-resistant in the first 5 feet, lean and clean to 30 feet, fuel reduced to 100 feet with grass at four inches or less.

MAY AND JUNE: FINISH DEFENSIBLE SPACE BEFORE THE HEAT

- ☐ Dead vegetation removed, tree branches limbed up at least 6 feet from the ground, wood piles moved out of the first 30 feet.
- ☐ Clear the roof and gutters of needles again. They are ember beds in summer and dams in winter.
- ☐ Expect that CAL FIRE conducts defensible space inspections in the State Responsibility Area covering much of this valley. Don't count on a warning first.
- ☐ **Generator month.** Start it, run it under load, check the fuel supply. Outdoors only, more than 20 feet from windows, doors, and vents, and never plugged into house wiring without a proper transfer switch.

JULY AND AUGUST: VIGILANCE AND THE SMALL STUFF

- ☐ Keep the first five feet around the house bare of dry debris. Redwood duff keeps falling all summer.

- ☐ Confirm your CruzAware registration is current, especially after a new phone or carrier, and check your PG&E outage alerts.
- ☐ Refresh the emergency kit: rotate stored water at one gallon per person per day, and swap expired food and medications.
- ☐ On a private well, this is the sensible season for pump or tank service, when a day without water is an annoyance rather than a crisis.

SEPTEMBER AND OCTOBER: THE BIG PUSH BEFORE THE RAINS

- ☐ Clean gutters and downspouts, and clear every ditch, drain, and culvert you own.
- ☐ Get roof repairs done while roofers can still get to you.
- ☐ Deal with dead limbs over the house, cars, and power drops. Tree crews book out fast once storms are in the forecast, so call early.
- ☐ Wood stove or fireplace serviced, chimney swept, before burning season.
- ☐ Propane tank filled, before delivery schedules tighten for everyone.
- ☐ Restock the storm side of the kit: flashlights, batteries, radio, and sandbags if your parcel needs them.

NOVEMBER AND DECEMBER: SWITCH TO STORM MODE

- ☐ Keep vehicles fueled ahead of big systems.
- ☐ Check drainage after each of the first storms; that is when you find what you missed.
- ☐ Keep generator fuel fresh and the extension cords somewhere you can find them in the dark.
- ☐ Replace the battery in any 9-volt alarm at least once a year. Pick a date you will remember.
- ☐ Photograph the house and outbuildings for insurance, back the photos up off the mountain, and confirm the policy matches what is actually on the parcel.

THE BEAT THAT IGNORES THE SEASONS

Alarms: test smoke alarms monthly and replace any alarm more than 10 years old.

Septic, which is most of Boulder Creek: have the system inspected at least every three years, and expect to pump the tank every three to five. Systems with pumps or floats want a yearly check.

Put both on a calendar you will actually see. Neither one reminds you until it fails, and a failed drainfield is one of the most expensive surprises a mountain house can serve up.

Defensible space out to 100 feet is required under Public Resources Code 4291. This calendar is a planning aid, not a code compliance document; confirm what applies to your parcel with **CAL FIRE** and the **Boulder Creek Fire Protection District**, (831) 338-7222.

Zone and limbing guidance from CAL FIRE; alarm testing and replacement intervals from the U.S. Fire Administration; generator placement from the CDC; septic inspection and pumping intervals from the EPA; kit contents from ready.gov. County road dispatch and water district numbers verified against the agencies' own sites. Checked July 2026.